Royal College of Art
Postgraduate Art and Design

Programme Specification

1. General Information

Programme title:	Service Design
Award:	Master's
Qualification Framework Level:	Level 7
School/Department or equivalent:	School of Communication & Design
Campus location(s):	Battersea
Total UK credits:	180
Date valid from/to	2026-27

2. Programme Philosophy

Service Design is evolving fast in a world where we see a historic transformation in how we respond to the uncertainties brought by advanced technologies & AI, the climate crisis, and societal change.

Service Design is the application of a 'designerly' way of thinking and working to respond to these uncertainties and is guided by a set of mindsets, principles and methods that are collaborative, innovative, pragmatic and systematic. As the subject evolves, its fields of inquiry and practice expand to include a spectrum from developing services for human experience to enabling transdisciplinary innovation and social change.

The Service Design programme equips you with cutting-edge thinking and tools to provide human insight, engage with complex systems and create and prototype new futures to become an effective changemaker in the modern world.

The learning and teaching is mostly project-based, and you will develop your practice through working on projects in teams. This includes collaborations with commercial, public sector or social organisations who bring real issues and opportunities for future disruption or innovation. Collaborating in teams, you will move through the design process of deep research, issue reframing, creative concept generation, prototyping and user testing. In developing your practice, you are encouraged to take a critical and reflective view of Service Design to develop your confidence in contributing to the development of Service Design as a practice and subject.

3. Educational Aims and Learning Outcomes of the Programme

<u>Programme aims</u>

To develop service designers who can:

- Apply service design methods to influence and transform complex systems to deliver positive impact and innovative business and social outcomes;
- Engage and create responses to changes and trends in technological, societal and business contexts;
- Operate in the culture and systems of organisational change;
- Imagine and deliver new services and experiences;
- Collaborate and lead transformational change.

<u>Learning Outcomes</u>

Upon successful completion of the programme, you will be expected to meet the requirements of both the College-wide Learning Outcomes and your programme-specific Learning Outcomes.

College-Wide Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Interrogate and articulate the intentions of your work in relation to the critical and conceptual context of your field(s) of study;
- Independently plan and produce work that is informed by developments at the forefront of your field(s) of study;
- Evaluate and critique the principles and methods of research in your field(s) of study, and apply these principles to your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice;
- Demonstrate originality in how you translate knowledge into practice;
- Communicate your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice to a non-specialist audience;
- Critically reflect on the likely public impact of your creative, professional and/or scholarly practice, and on your responsibilities as a practitioner;
- Define your professional ambitions and identify the challenges involved in meeting them.

Programme-Specific Learning Outcomes

You should be able to:

- Articulate the fundamentals of a service, assess the ways service design is applied to a specific area of practice, and appraise the value and limitations of service design practice for addressing real world challenges;
- Design and construct a service design project that synthesises the core elements of the practice;
- Critically evaluate and articulate the rationale for your choices of service design tools and methods, and assess how to reformulate or develop them to work in specific contexts to address issues including inclusivity, equity and diversity;
- Develop strategies to engender creativity and imagination in yourself and others, through the development and design of innovative outputs;
- Evaluate and articulate the intended and actual impact of the design outputs of a project, and interpret and articulate the challenges of applying service design practice to specific project contexts, e.g. health, sustainability, AI and policy;
- Synthesise and evaluate the challenges of collaborative working to develop strategies for planning, managing and delivering design projects, based on careful evaluation of design ethics, required resources, potential outcome and measurement of impact;
- Develop a clear narrative for your work that synthesises the new knowledge and outcomes generated by your projects and that can engage both expert and non-expert audiences.

4. What Will I Learn?

Curriculum Map

Term 1	Term 2	Term 3
Service Design Foundation (15 credits)	Grand Challenge (15 credits)	

Service Design Practice (30 credits)	Service Design in Context (30 credits)	Independent Research Project (60 credits)
Across RCA (15 credits)	Core Skills (15 credits)	

Programme Structure

Unit Title	Term	Credit Value	Core or Elective?
Service Design Foundation	1	15	Core
Service Design Practice	1	30	Core
AcrossRCA (College-wide unit)	1	15	Core
Service Design in Context	2	30	Core
Grand Challenge (School unit)	2	15	Core
Core Skills	2	15	Core
Independent Research Project	3	60	Core

The first two terms will take you from a foundation of the tools and methodologies through to advanced techniques and management skills which are applied through projects leading to the Independent Research Project in the third term.

Term 1: Service Design Foundation introduces the theories and concepts underpinning service and service design practice. You will deliver a small-scale and analytically focused project in a team setting. In Service Design Practice, you will apply service design tools and methods to deliver a ‘live’ project in dialogue with industry partners, to address a selected challenge in an area, e.g. health, sustainability, business innovation and social inclusion.

In Term 1 you will also participate in AcrossRCA. This unit aims to support you to meet the challenges of a complex, uncertain and changing world by enabling you to work collaboratively in cross-programme interdisciplinary teams. In your team you will develop a self-initiated themed project, informed by expertise within and beyond the College. These projects will challenge you to use your intellect and imagination collectively to address key cultural, social, environmental and economic challenges. In doing so, you will develop and reflect on the abilities required to translate knowledge into action and help demonstrate the contribution that creative practices can make to our understanding and experience of the world.

Term 2: In Service Design in Context, you will develop a project proposal for the Independent Research Project, by examining the relationship between practice and context, and the impact of service design projects on economic, technological, social, cultural and environmental systems and how these contexts shape the implementation of service ideas. In Core Skills you will advance your academic and professional skills by developing knowledge, strategies and tools for sensemaking, collaboration and public engagement in and through design.

Term 3: The Independent Research Project is self-directed, with the aim that you develop and establish yourself as a professional service designer in your chosen areas of expertise within the diverse spectrum of service design practice. You will develop strategic visions with practical, deliverable design interventions to create new services and systems. This project will be the core of the public output of the programme and should contribute to public discourse on the value and suitability of the services and interactions we experience.

In term 2 you will participate in the Grand Challenge alongside students within and across the School. The aim of this unit is to connect and challenge all students through the introduction of a 'wicked' design problem that requires a cross-disciplinary approach to problem solving which may involve external international partners. This unit and lecture series has been hugely successful in connecting and disrupting disciplines, people, philosophies and approaches to design thinking whilst providing our student body with very unique networking opportunities.

There are three Independent Study weeks included in your programme (one per term). During these weeks there will be no scheduled teaching or assessment, and limited access to Technical Services. Self-service will be available for inducted users, and you may independently use computing and technology zones, bench spaces, and the resources store and art shop. These weeks are intended for you to work independently, and technical supervision, fabrication support, or supervision of high-risk activities will not be available.

5. How Will I Learn?

We aim to create a studio-based learning environment where you learn by doing projects in collaboration with your peers, addressing a range of real-world challenges, e.g. health inequality, the green transition, designing for cities, emerging technology and AI.

The project work is guided by regular sessions with tutors who work with you throughout each project. You will have the opportunity to describe relevant research, hypotheses and potential outcomes with tutors as your project develops.

The studio-based learning is complemented with a series of lectures and seminars, covering the theoretical principles, practical examples, and methods of service design.

Topics include the impact and future direction of service design, human and digital interactions, user research and the generation of insight, design ethics, total system design and approaches to prototyping and testing.

Where study visits are a core part of the teaching, these are in the London area and you will only pay for travel expenses. Any extra-curricular visits/trips are optional and will be at your own expense.

A public event is held towards the end of the Independent Research Project.

Your studies are divided into three terms and comprise scheduled staff-led time such as lectures, seminars and tutorials, as well as independent learning. Each term consists of 60 credits which equates to 600 study hours. During each week you should, as a full-time student, expect about 40 study hours. This is made up of two components:

- contact hours (approximately 5-10 per week) which involve timetabled interaction with tutors (for example, in seminars, critiques and tutorials), fostering intellectual exchange by way of clarifying concepts, addressing key questions and cultivating critical thinking;
- the time you dedicate to developing your work independently (in addition to the contact hours) by way of self-directed study which can include activities such as making in the workshops, working in the studio, conducting research or preparing for assessment.

The amount of time you spend in self-directed, independent study will normally increase as you progress to the final term, particularly as you focus on the public exhibition or completion of your work. The precise pattern of contact hours will vary by unit, term and mode of study.

6. Assessment and Feedback

Regulations
The programme is subject to the Academic Regulations of the Royal College of Art (*the regulations are subject to annual updates and amendments*).
Unit Assessment
Project-based learning is an important aspect of the programme. For all units your work will be assessed against the learning outcomes. In your programme units, the assessment will be in a group setting for the project as presentations, and your individual learnings will be assessed through your reflection on the projects. In unit 3, the assessment will be written work both in group and individually. Both summative and formative assessment is used in all units to support your learning. Information regarding individual assessments will be included in the unit descriptors, available at the beginning of the academic year.

7. What Award Can I Get?

To be awarded an RCA MA degree you need to gain 180 credits at level 7 of the Framework for Higher Education Qualifications (FHEQ). This will involve successfully completing all units. Exit awards: If you have gained at least 60 credits at Level 7, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Certificate. If you have gained at least 120 credits at level 7 of the FHEQ, you may be eligible for the exit award of Postgraduate Diploma.